From this high point in India–US strategic relations, the level of engagement and cooperation quickly declined. India and the US had drawn closer during the India–China war, with plans for further military cooperation. In the event, the American military pipeline soon dried up. The Anglo-American insistence in 1963 that India negotiate with Pakistan reignited Delhi's resentment of London's and Washington's role in South Asia. Also, India wanted to refurbish its non-aligned credentials and put some distance between itself and the US. The death of Kennedy in November 1963 and Nehru a few months later in 1964 brought leadership change in both countries and a less positive view of the bilateral relationship. In 1965, the US began to send its combat troops into Vietnam, which led to years of Indian criticism. During the September 1965 war with Pakistan, Washington stopped all military aid to both South Asian countries – the halt in aid suggested it was not a reliable partner. Stung by Delhi's criticism of his Vietnam policy and annoyed by Mrs Gandhi's socialistic policies, Kennedy's successor, Lyndon Johnson, insisted that India devalue its currency and carry out agricultural reforms in order to qualify for development assistance. When India urgently needed US grains to deal with its food shortages, Johnson instituted a 'short-tether' policy of releasing tranches of foodgrains conditional on Indian economic reforms.

## *The China–US détente*

Even as Delhi's relations with Moscow deepened and its relations with Washington deteriorated, China and the US were eyeing a détente. While Nixon is correctly credited with the diplomatic opening to China, Kennedy had been contemplating a change of policy as early as 1963.[13] In 1965, under Johnson, the US lifted the travel ban to China, and in February 1965, it announced that Chinese journalists could visit the US. Johnson publicly declared that reconciliation with China was inevitable.[14] America's growing involvement in the Vietnam war caused Beijing to recoil. Also, back at home, Mao was preoccupied with internal reform and his own grip on